
Everyday (Virtual) Life

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Everyday (Virtual) Life

Mark Poster

THE CONCEPT OF EVERYDAY LIFE has been central to the discourse of critical theory at least since the early 1960s when Henri Lefebvre devoted several volumes to elaborating the idea.¹ In this essay I shall review the category of the everyday and test its critical capacities in the current context, when information machines or media have been disseminated widely in places like the home and the street, perhaps undermining the boundary between the quotidian and the extraordinary, the private and the public. I shall argue that the media transform place and space in such a way that what had been regarded as the locus of the everyday can no longer be distinguished as separate from its opposite. This change operates to nullify earlier notions of the everyday but also opens the possibility for a reconfigured concept of daily life which might yet contain critical potentials.²

Humanism and Everyday Life

A review of Lefebvre's concept of the everyday provides insight into the distance that separates us from critical positions of the immediate postwar period. Lefebvre's intervention in that discourse upset the prevailing conceptual registers. To be critical of domination in the early postwar years, for Lefebvre, meant to call into question the freedoms offered by representative democracy, capitalism, or the state socialism of the Soviet Union and the Eastern European bloc of nations. Freedom, in his view, could not be realized in these institutional frames of practice. In the first instance, the everyday was the region outside official politics and large economic organizations. The locus of an "other" to public life was the first step in redefining human freedom. He writes in *Critique of Everyday Life* in 1947 that "the critique of everyday life involves a critique of political life, in that everyday life already contains and constitutes such a critique: in that it *is* that critique."³ The issue at stake in the concept of daily life therefore was the recognition of the failure of big politics to offer anything like an adequate domain for human life.

In order to define the everyday Lefebvre took over from phenomenology and existentialism the notion of "lived experience," *le vécu, Erlebnis*.

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The category of lived experience functioned in Edmund Husserl's *Phenomenology and the Crisis of the European Sciences*, in Martin Heidegger's early existentialism of *Being and Time*, and in French translations and adaptations of these works such as Jean-Paul Sartre's *Being and Nothingness* and Maurice Merleau-Ponty's *Phenomenology of Perception* as a critique of rationalist metaphysics deriving from Cartesian, Kantian, and Hegelian traditions. These newer philosophies of the 1920s to the 1950s rejected the ordering of the world through the category of reflected reason, opening the understanding of the human condition precisely to everyday experience. One might say that these critiques of reason-centered reality were the first steps toward positions which inspire much of critical thinking today, from poststructuralist theory to the cultural studies traditions. The crucial leap was to get outside the Western worldview in which reality moved toward and was moved by reason—not to assert an opposite to reason as in the writings of romantic philosophy and literature, but to test the limits of what we now call logocentrism, to demote it in status as simply one, however important, regime of rationality. Lived experience could serve Lefebvre as a critical notion only because it was not defined completely within something known as reason.

Lefebvre was aware of the dangers of turning to everyday life as a critical category. Heidegger's treatment of the everyday in *Being and Time*, for instance, was that of the realm of alienation, of the forgetfulness of Being. Lefebvre acknowledges Heidegger's view when he defines the everyday as the "concrete," as "lived experience," but also as "alienation." He points to "a problem which is fundamental for the critique of everyday life. . . . Many men . . . do not know their own lives very well. . . . Men have no knowledge of their own lives: they see them and act them out via ideological themes and ethical values" (C92). Lack of self-reflection does not automatically lead to critique or to a space of liberation. Quite the opposite: the normal life is one of ideological distortion, of absorption into the language of domination, of the internalization of the false prescriptions and ideals of the hegemonic institutions.

Notwithstanding its dangers, the everyday still offers a point of resistance. This is so because it has no status within the dominant regimes of politics and economics. If modern society is constituted by the separation of distinct spheres into organized practices known as institutions, as Max Weber argues,⁴ then whatever is informal, unorganized, serendipitous, and chaotic may be considered the everyday. True enough, the everyday is subject to a distracted participation in ideology. Nonetheless it escapes institutional appropriation by the massive powers of the state and the economy. And for this reason, Lefebvre finds much

in the everyday to offer hope and optimism. Here is Lefebvre's most articulated definition of everyday life:

Everyday life, in a sense residual, defined by "what is left over" after all distinct, superior, specialized, structured activities have been singled out by analysis, must be defined as a totality. . . . Everyday life is profoundly related to *all* activities, and encompasses them with all their differences and their conflicts; it is their meeting place, their bond, their common ground. And it is in everyday life that the sum total of relations which make the human—and every human being—a whole takes its shape and its form. In it are expressed and fulfilled those relations which bring into play the totality of the real, albeit in a certain manner which is always partial and incomplete: friendship, comradeship, love, the need to communicate, play, etc. . . . the critique of everyday life studies human nature in its concreteness. (C 97)

If there is a center to Lefebvre's use of the term "everyday life" this passage provides the best representation of it.

There is one other effort Lefebvre made to develop a concept of the everyday that is worth noting. In an encyclopedia article entitled "The Everyday and Everydayness," Lefebvre condensed several volumes devoted to the topic into a few pages. Here he underscores what was to become one of the central aspects of the discussion of the everyday in the discourse of cultural studies: its constructedness. "The everyday," Lefebvre proclaims, "is a *product*."⁵ The everyday is created through the destruction of pre-modernity and the erection of modern society. In this process, material shortages, he argues, disappeared, and the older referents for history, religion, and space itself became disconnected from practices. Out of this wreckage emerged the everyday, the remainder so to speak, the last refuge of meaning. In its modern form, Lefebvre continues, the everyday is a domain of "passivity," of "organized passivity" in "work, family, private life, leisure." For him, the passivity of the everyday is most acute in the domain of consumption where "the needs of the consumer [are] created by advertising and market studies" (E 10). Only if a revolution transforms this passivity into a festival will humanity escape the banality of the everyday, he concludes.

As I define the problems with this concept of the everyday, it is worth bearing in mind that Lefebvre wrote neither with Immanuel Kant's systematicity nor with Friedrich Nietzsche's aphoristic style, his refusal of linear logic. Lefebvre's books are compendia of thoughts that, in a negative light, threaten to disperse into incoherence or, more favorably, are charming, conversational explorations of themes.⁶ The intention of the rest of my remarks concerning his work is not to diminish his image in the eyes of social theorists, nor to disparage his acumen. Instead I

regard it as the task of critical theory to define a new frame for understanding the everyday. Lefebvre's definition in this passage reveals the limits of the utility of his work for this effort.

In Lefebvre's characterization of the everyday we find the terms "residual," "total," and "human concreteness." We have seen that "residual" refers to a domain that is outside politics and economics, the great public spheres of modernity. The residual is an opposite that preserves opposition; it is the locus of resistance to what it is not. Thereby Lefebvre confirms the project of modernity, as Jürgen Habermas would say,⁷ even as he shifts its site from politics and economics to the vague place of the residual. Within the residual, one salient feature of modernity—resistance to oppression—is preserved, redefined, and perhaps expanded. With the term "residual," Lefebvre initiates a sharp turn of direction in the metanarrative of modernity: the democratic state and the capitalist organization of industry are no longer directly the spaces in which resistance to freedom may develop. The citizen and the worker are no longer the figures in whom are registered the hopes of modernity for greater autonomy. True enough: a successful radical movement would have to confront the practices of the state and the economy, opening them and transforming them in the spirit of collective responsibility. Lefebvre's concept of the everyday as the residual, in this sense, may be said to have anticipated what came to be called in the 1970s the new social movements—feminism, ecology, consumer rights, human rights, antinuclear and antiracist politics—which might be extended today to include postcolonialism, queer theory, transgender groups, and antiglobalization protest. While each of these groups might have some connection with the critique of the liberal state and market ideology, they arguably may be said to emerge from the everyday. Each of them, in different ways, expands and redefines what came down from the nineteenth century as the scope of human freedom. While this is not the place to specify those expansions, Lefebvre's notion of the everyday holds its place as a move in the direction of a postmodern politics, discovering areas of trouble beyond the rights of the citizen and the worker.

If the term "residual" opens the project of modernity to new interests, the other terms in Lefebvre's definition of the everyday, "totality" and "human concreteness," draw the lines of critique back within the modern, reproducing in the realm of the everyday the criteria of opposition that characterized the fields of the political and the economic. Everyday life for him is residual, to be sure, but also and paradoxically all-encompassing. It is a region in which the human is most fully expressed in its totality. The human is now figured as love, play, friendship, communication, not the eradication of poverty and the dissolution of tyranny which were its earlier referents. Although Lefebvre

has altered the traits of the human, it is still the human and it is still the human in its totality that is at issue. Abandoning the shop floor and the state house, Lefebvre attaches to the everyday the utopian space of the truly free individual. The terms, one will notice, remain the same in both cases. Lefebvre's concept of everyday life reproduces the quest for the subject of freedom, however displaced it may be from its historical locations. "Totality" and "human concreteness" are thus excessive terms, attempting to do too much (to find more than any term reasonably can) and also achieve too little (they obscure the difficulties of any position in fulfilling their criteria). His terms are mythic and ontological, wanting to insert into the everyday the prefigured telos of freedom.

Given these difficulties, it should not be surprising to find Lefebvre deeply disappointed when he turns to the actual features of the contemporary everyday. Far from the total realization of human concreteness, the everyday looks more to him like Heidegger's realm of inauthenticity. Lefebvre writes in the 1958 foreword to the second edition of *Critique of Everyday Life: Volume 1*:

We are now entering the vast domain of the *illusory reverse image*. What we find is a false world: firstly because it is not a world, and because it presents itself as true, and because it mimics real life closely in order to replace the real by its opposite; by replacing real unhappiness by fictions of happiness, for example—by offering a fiction in response to the real need for happiness—and so on. This is the "world" of most films, most of the press, the theatre, the music hall: of a large sector of leisure activities.

How strange the split between the real world and its reverse image is. For in the end it is not strange at all, but a false strangeness, a cheap-and-nasty, all-pervasive mystery. (C 35)

Far from a domain of unfettered play, love, and friendship, the everyday world of leisure in the arts and the media presents reality as an "illusory reverse image," a camera obscura effect that sounds very much like Karl Marx's classic definition of ideology. Lefebvre is disconsolate in finding the "human concreteness" of the everyday distorted systematically in those places where it might be furthered, enhanced, represented and advocated. Apparently frustrated by what he sees, Lefebvre casts about for an evil agent responsible for the mess and finds one in "bourgeois decadence" (C 127). Perhaps the wicked bourgeoisie is only playing its familiar role in the drama of the everyday whose director is Lefebvre himself, or at least his theory of the everyday as the "residue" of "totality" and "human concreteness." Because the reality of the everyday proves less than expected, Lefebvre scapegoats the bourgeoisie.

If things turned sour in 1958, they became bitter in 1968. Just as the historic May events were unfolding, Lefebvre's *Everyday Life in the Modern*

World, a one-volume revision of *Critique of Everyday Life*, appeared. If the earlier volume denounced the arts and the media, along with the vile bourgeoisie, for the corruption of everyday life, the new volume discerned a level of organized control over everyday life that was not noticed earlier. One is reminded of Norman Angell's prediction of perpetual peace as a consequence of international trade appearing just on the eve of World War I.⁸ In the same week that France erupted into the largest strike in modern history, witnessing a comprehensive rejection of authority at every social level, Lefebvre's book announced the collapse of freedom into the totally administered society: "In the modern world everyday life had ceased to be a 'subject' rich in potential subjectivity; it had become an 'object' of social organization."⁹ Lefebvre continues "Everyday life has become an object of consideration and is the province of organization; the space-time of voluntary programmed self-regulation, because when properly organized it provides a closed circuit (production-consumption-production), where demands are foreseen because they are induced and desires are run to earth; this method replaces the spontaneous self-regulation of the competitive era. Thus everyday life must shortly become the one perfect system obscured by the other systems that aim at systematizing thought and structuralizing action" (*ELM* 72). Perhaps I am unfair in juxtaposing the events of May 1968 with the appearance of Lefebvre's book. After all, he wrote a celebration of these events shortly thereafter in which he found new hope in everyday life.¹⁰ And the achievements of May 1968 were as fleeting as the disasters of World War I were permanent.

Lefebvre's analysis of everyday life in 1968, however, is the other side of the coin of his presentation in 1958: instead of the fulfillment of "total" "human concreteness" from the earlier book we now have the "subject" being lost and becoming an "object." This sharp inversion in the condition of everyday life is produced by a problem with Lefebvre's understanding of everyday life, that is, its reliance on a figure of the human and the subject. Lefebvre's humanism, his turn to the everyday as the place of complete humanity, limits his ability to discern crucial qualities of the everyday, and, for our purposes, leads to a blindness concerning the media. His contention that everyday life in 1968 is a "closed circuit of production-consumption-production" neither prepares him for the surprise of May 1968 nor points to a heuristic analysis of the place of the media and changes in the media in relation to culture. The discussion of Lefebvre's move to the everyday points us to the conceptual need for a theory of the quotidian that enables a grasp of the specific cultural mechanisms through which the subject is constituted, and by which the subject constitutes its world. There are three analytic keys to this understanding: language, consumption, and media.

Lefebvre's understanding of language was shaped by his response to the emergence of structuralism and poststructuralism in the 1960s. He devoted several volumes to this issue, notably *Le langage et la société* (1966) and *Au-delà du structuralisme* (1971). In both volumes he dismissed the new intellectual trends as vacuous and politically inept, and developed in response a critical and social theory of language, one that proved influential to his student, Jean Baudrillard. Lumping together structuralists, semioticians, and poststructuralists, Lefebvre rejected what he saw as their ahistorical theory of language, misconstruing it as determinist. The new theories of language for him failed to account for the element of domination in the social system. To that end, he proposed a revision of the Saussurian concept of the sign in which the distinction between signifier and signified was not a quality of language as such but a consequence of the manipulation of culture by the capitalist media. In an important formulation, he denounced the splitting of signifiers and signifieds as resulting in a "floating stock of *meaningless signifiers* (stray images either conscious or unconscious)" (ELM 118).¹¹ The term "floating signifiers" would prove useful in the critique of the culture of language and media by Baudrillard. Lefebvre himself did not advance beyond his condemnation of the phenomenon to analyze the cultural mechanisms through which floating signifiers appeared in everyday life, how these constituted new subject positions, and how the new language pattern might be the locus of a critique that pointed to possible cultural formations that might not realize "human concreteness" and the "total" subject.

If Lefebvre's critique of language in everyday life failed to articulate positions beyond familiar left humanism, his view of consumerism also was seriously limited. Again one finds that Lefebvre is sensitive to a change in the nature of consumption, a new concern with the cultural aspects of an activity previously associated with material exhaustion of objects. In the following passage from *Everyday Life in the Modern World*, Lefebvre complains that consumption has become a mystified embrace of symbols:

Consuming of displays, displays of consuming. Consuming of displays of consuming, consuming of signs and signs of consuming; each sub-system, as it tries to close the circuit, gives another self-destructive twist, at the level of everyday life. . . . Thus every object and product acquires a dual existence, perceptible and make-believe; all that can be consumed becomes a symbol of consumption and the consumer is fed on symbols, symbols of dexterity and wealth, of happiness and of love; sign and significance replace reality, there is a vast substitution, a massive transfer, that is nothing but an illusion created by the swivel's giddy twists. (ELM 108)

The shift to the consumption of symbols, a crucial aspect of postmodern consumer practices,¹² is registered by Lefebvre as a fall from “reality.” One cannot begin to explore everyday life after the mid-twentieth century with such a humanist metaphysic.

The third central feature of an analytic of everyday life, the media, is not touched upon by Lefebvre. A shift to the media requires an understanding of language and consumption such that the role of the media becomes a question. Once everyday life is extracted from the humanist frame of Lefebvre, it becomes available for a cultural study of the position of specific media, of how particular media participate in constructing cultural forms in the domains of language and consumption. This proves to be a highly complex task for the cultural analyst, in part because of the agency of information machines. The framework of subject-object that so profoundly shapes modernist cultural analysis cannot serve as guide in a domain of everyday life where machines are central features of the landscape. The emergence of new media since the 1990s has raised this issue to a new level of urgency, stimulating important initiatives that are too numerous to list here.¹³ In the next section of this essay, I shall indicate some of the questions that arise for an understanding of everyday life when attention is paid to media. I shall risk an analysis of my own experience of media in order to explore some of the dangers and opportunities the media instigate.

Autobiographical Investigations: The Media and Me

The study of the place of media in everyday life is plagued with difficulties. Media mediate. They go between established social and cultural positions and between the categories deployed to comprehend these positions. They are machines—neither subjects nor objects, minds nor bodies, persons nor things, but both at the same time and yet different from each. They enter our lives in funny ways, obliquely, behind the back of our cultural self-understanding. The standard Western notion of machines as tools, with users as subjects and machines as objects, with a utilitarian ethic presumed for the subject and a privilege given to the subject’s intentionality or consciousness—this longstanding framework for fitting tools into culture does not do justice to the complexity of the practice of humans with information machines. Since the introduction of print, each generation has confronted the issue of media, taking as given the media that existed in its youth, and responding variously with anxiety or joy to the placement of new media in society. In what follows, I analyze my relation to several media in the order I encountered them, attempting to understand how each medium

altered my subject position. I include only a few of the media I encountered since a comprehensive discussion is beyond the scope of this essay.

My purpose differs from standard autobiography. I am not attempting to illuminate my singular life or to confess moral events. I am not even trying to contextualize my life, indicating its contingencies and historical determinations. Instead I hope to use my experience as a case study of the historic synergy of human and information machine. By demonstrating how profound and extensive has been the role of media in my life, I offer a model to further the conceptualization of everyday life.¹⁴

The example of radio illustrates a fundamental feature of all media: that they bring diverse cultures into close contact, a degree of proximity not possible without them. In this way, media accentuate greatly the tendency of daily city life to mix populations from different ethnic or racial origins. Media enact this mixing in ways different from the urban topography. Juxtaposing cultures in media is often haphazard and instantaneous, whereas cities feature neighborhoods with particular ethnic groupings. Media tend in this respect to destabilize local customs, to extend awareness of other ways of life, and to add complexity to the process of socialization.

A boy of six or seven in the mid- to late 1940s, living in the Flatbush area of Brooklyn, I was introduced to new cultures through the radio. I remember clearly being in bed with a cold and turning the radio dial in boredom until tuning in a country-and-western music station, music I had never heard before that was foreign to the culture of my upbringing. The whining plaintive sounds from throats and violins that emanated from the small speaker were a revelation to me. I had never heard anything like it and could not imagine the cultural context from which it sprang (I had not yet seen western movies or television shows). There I was, alone in the bedroom, listening to the strange sounds and being fascinated by them. The radio brought me a new culture. At the same time, it opened my sensorium to music: I would continue to love music to this day. I learned the saxophone and clarinet, playing in high school bands and ROTC band. I also love recorded music. But more of that later.

Perhaps of greater interest than my experience of the radio was that of my schoolmate a few years later in Queens, Paul Simon. He reported in a TV interview in the late 1990s having heard rhythm and blues, rock and roll, and other black music on the radio in Kew Garden Hills, an area with few African Americans. In both his case and mine, the radio allowed the introduction of other cultures in a manner outside the control of parents, although admittedly the consequences were far greater of his listening than of mine. Children could discover cultures

through music that otherwise would remain unavailable to them. The youth culture and popular music of the 1960s were deeply affected by the radio, and in turn they contributed significantly to other forms of popular culture that would take by storm not only the United States but the world.

During the years of my youth, the radio was a fixture in my family's home. I did not regard it as special in any way. When I listened to country-and-western music that day, I did not appreciate the radio itself, had no sense of its ability to overcome geographic and social distance. My focus was totally on the music. Yet I had made a bond with the radio. Mark-radio could now enjoy this music at any time. Unlike Radio Raheem in Spike Lee's film, *Do the Right Thing* (1989), I could not take the radio with me through the streets. But I could come back to it after a day at school, back to its fixed place in my home, and turn the dials to connect with a culture remote from the middle-class Jewish world that I knew. In fact, when I began to hear Jewish music, mostly at summer camps, I regarded it as exotic and strange compared with radio music.

The radio I heard in Brooklyn came from the culture industry, the media corporations that had controlled the airwaves since the onset of broadcasting in the 1920s. In Britain in the 1970s, the Anglo-African community refunctioned radio to suit the needs of their community.¹⁵ Pirate radio, as it was known in mainstream media, enabled the local community to hear music unavailable on the commercial and public stations. In addition, the disc jockeys employed the newer cassette technology to compose music with bits and pieces from the culture and politics of the day. Inexpensive radio transmitters along with cheap cassette recorders formed an assemblage that empowered the Anglo-African community and enriched their daily lives with the music of their choice. The question of control in everyday life arises from the examples of British pirate radio and my listening. Shall we understand the dissemination of information machines in everyday life under the sign of democratization?

My experience of radio was isolated. I listened usually alone in a room to a station of my choice. Radio did not intercede between me and my family but substituted for other activities I might do without any company. Not so with television. Television was watched by the family as a whole, displacing conversation, parlor games, and other forms of conviviality. Television introduced into the home a collective popular culture, one beyond the family.¹⁶ Since there were, in the 1950s, few stations, everyone with televisions tended to watch the same programs.¹⁷ In my experience, radio simply brought to my attention alternatives to

my immediate cultural surroundings; television introduced into the home a new national culture, one with which the family could not compete.¹⁸

My father, I later realized, was an early adopter of information technologies. He was an accountant whose busy season was tax time. He insisted I help him at these times and I recall the early copy machines and primitive adding machines he used. The copy machines were messy affairs, with specially coated paper and liquids of all sorts. The world of work, I learned, was also saturated with information machines.

But in 1949, shortly after the introduction of nationally broadcast television shows, he purchased a TV. Aside from images of Howdy Doody and Milton Berle my clearest memory is of neighbors filling our modest-sized living room to watch and listen in awe to our nine-inch Admiral television set, a large free-standing object with lots of polished wood encasing the tube. In these early days, television created a community of sorts. My family and neighbors all marveled at the technical feat of broadcast moving images and sound. Here was something new and important. Yet to my young eyes television was interesting but not astonishing. It was easy to accept its novelty; it did not seem extraordinary. I suppose this is a basic difference between adults and children in the reception of new media.

Television's greatest emotional effect on me was through sporting events. I remember distinctly my profound disappointment and frustration when in September 1951, Bobby Thompson hit a home run against the Dodgers to give the Giants the pennant. I was alone in front of the television with no one to share this depressing event, just the tube, which disgusted me deeply.

These media—radio and television—impacted my life in important ways. I recall that the technical feats they accomplished did not surprise me in the least. I simply accepted that text, images, and sound could appear from outside my small world. While the wonders of these media affected me deeply at times, my life was concentrated mostly on sports and friends. Playing baseball, stickball, basketball, and football were the really important occasions of my life. The rest was supplementary (broadcast sports events) or marginal (country-and-western music, sci-fi films and novels). In my youth, activities with others took priority over mediated experience. Nonetheless, radio and television entered into my life and altered significantly the contours of everyday experience.¹⁹ I learned skills of shifting registers from face-to-face relations to information machines and back. Growing up the 1940s and 1950s, I was moving increasingly toward a culture of multiplicity. If the ethnic mix I encountered in these early years was limited, the ontological mix of human and

machine was rich and diverse. Multiculturalism began for me through the mediation of information machines and only later extended to street life.

In junior high school in 1953 students were required to take a course in typing. I had little interest in the machine at the time, but learning to touch type has proven to be an invaluable skill. When I went off to college in 1958, I received as a gift a Royal portable electric typewriter which I used for years, and even wrote my dissertation on it. Even though typing was considered a menial skill beneath the dignity of a future "professional," I accepted it and grew to enjoy using the machine. When I arrived in California, having never traveled west of Philadelphia, on September 2, 1969, to take an assistant professorship at the University of California at Irvine, my office equipment consisted of a dictionary and a typewriter.

A good portion of my work life has consisted since then in using a keyboard. For any reader of my generation, I need not belabor the difference between an electro-mechanical keyboard and a computer keyboard. The former, Friedrich Kittler and William Burroughs notwithstanding,²⁰ was a miserable affair. Changing text required messy liquids and powders. Multiple copies, with carbon papers which inevitably left stains on clothing and hands, were truly bothersome. On these machines, the transfer of the life of the mind into material form was difficult work. Often this work was subcontracted (as we now say) to full-time typists. Because of the limits of the typewriter, writers did not produce texts in an edited form, but instead yielded manuscripts and typescripts almost unreadable with erasures, crossed out passages, marginal revisions, and scribbling of all kinds.

The electro-mechanical typewriter was truly a tool of the older kind. It required skill. It was a tool that resisted the subject's intentionality, demanding some physical force to produce markings on paper. The object that emerged from it bore the traces of labor—of the imperfections in the keys, the uneven spread of ink on the ribbon, and the variable force of the typist across the QWERTY. Computer keyboards, by contrast, elide these markings of the body. Word processing files appear to inscribe directly the intellect of the writer, obeying with precision the author's intentions. There are indeed experiments with disabled computer users in which the brain directly transposes its will to the screen, bypassing entirely the work of writing.²¹ Information machines have clearly transformed the domain of work, constructing symbiotic human-machines or cyborgs in the process.²²

The shift from the typewriter keyboard to the computer keyboard is ontological: the former instantiates and reinforces a subject-object

relation. The paper page receives the mechanical blows of the keys as the writer presses on the machine to produce the inked page. The typewriter merely improves the legibility of the page over the hand-manipulated quill, ink pen, or pencil, where one scratches inscriptions into the paper. The computer keyboard, by contrast, sends digital signals to the central processing chip through the word processing program, producing letters on the screen that lack the material properties of the typed paper page. The letters on the screen are fluid, easily changeable and movable. No more scratching out and brushing of white liquids. The words appear on the screen almost as quickly as they are thought or revised. Spelling and grammar are instantly checked. A thesaurus is only a few keystrokes away. Other files on one's machine are also ready to be marked, copied and pasted into the text. Bibliographical annotations are just as available not only from information existing in one's database but from other databases anywhere in the world. The same keyboard serves many functions not limited to word processing. Switching between programs magically transforms the keyboard into a calculator, an input system for a database, a music selector, a telegraph-like communication system, and so forth.

The keyboard is a liminal apparatus. It sutures the consciousness of the writer to the vast stores of information on the Net and the compelling facilities of the programs on one's machine. There is no opposition of creative mind to dumb (typewriting) machine, but rather interaction between writer, keyboard, computer program, and network, each having considerable cognitive abilities. The mind moves with the aid of the keyboard into the screen, merging with global information systems through the interface. Writing is no longer an isolated activity but one that affords simultaneous connections to others through chat rooms, E-mail, and instant messaging. And the keyboard, perhaps a collapsible one, moves with the user through everyday life far more easily than a portable typewriter, accompanying the user wherever she happens to be. The keyboard user is thus always, for better or worse, ready to write.

As a hi-fi snob, I was uninterested in portable cassette players introduced by Sony as the Walkman. My children were not so restricted, and quickly adopted the media. In the early 1980s, in a mall in Mission Viejo with my wife and daughters, I was bored by shopping. My younger daughter offered me her Walkman with a U2 cassette in it. I was astonished. Standing in the same position in the midst of clothing stores and the like, I was enveloped by the gorgeous, bleating sounds of *Joshua Tree*, literally displacing me from my surroundings. A simple audio device transported my consciousness to the musical "space." If radio

commingles cultures, shifting spatial arrangements, the Walkman blends in the same body different senses from divergent locations, in this case, sight from the mall with sound from U2's recording studio. Such alterations in the spatial and temporal configuration of the everyday urge us finally to consider the question that has been haunting these analyses: the control of daily culture.²³

Fortunately Michael Bull, in *Sounding Out the City*, has studied this question in relation to what he calls (to avoid the litigation of Sony Corporation) the personal stereo. Based on ethnographic interviews with users of Walkmen, Bull frames the diversity of their views in relation to the theory of the culture industry as developed by intellectuals of the Frankfurt School.²⁴ Bull pleads for a recognition of the importance of information machines in daily life, arguing that they afford individuals new levels of control over their daily lives. He writes, "The use of personal stereos greatly expands the possibilities for users to aesthetically recreate their daily experience" (S 86). For Bull, the Walkman alleviates the grind of daily routine but in the end accommodates the individual to the exigencies of late capitalism. The individual as agent escapes the ugliness and boredom of the city only to subsume herself to the offerings of the culture industry, in the form of both technology (the Walkman) and the music. The enhanced control rendered by the machine proves illusory to the analyst informed by Frankfurt School theory (S 156). We choose our music, but we lose the opportunity of mutual recognition that is the hallmark of the Western city: "Personal-stereo use demonstrates a structural negation of reciprocal forms of recognition as lying at the heart of everyday urban relations" (S 182).

Ubiquitous Computing

A final example of technoculture might shed new light on Bull's ambivalent conclusion, this one, alas, not from my personal experience, because it is a future development. In this case I refer to the imminent integration of computing with the body through miniaturization. Walkmen, personal digital assistants, cell phones with on-line capability, geographic positioning systems—these new appendages to the mobile body in everyday life soon will be supplemented with greatly increased computing power. At that point all the power of information technology will be harnessed by and coupled with the body.

The distribution of information machines throughout the space of the everyday proceeds apace. Major research laboratories devoted to digital technology, the MIT Media Lab in Cambridge and Xerox PARC in Palo Alto in particular, report on projects to bring computing power

to urban places inhabited hitherto only by humans and mechanical machines (with due recognition of cockroaches, rats, and the occasional plant). Streetlights, roads, fire hydrants, building facades are designated or already colonized by computer chips, video cameras, audio devices, and the like. Appliances inside and outside the home already bear digital commanders. From cars to humble toasters, computing power is everywhere. If industrial society has destroyed thousands of plant and animal species, it has replaced them with silicon in equally impressive variations. If the physical plant of the city and the mechanical devices inside buildings and vehicles harbor digital technology, so do the human populations. Walkmen, mobile phones, beepers, and personal digital assistants accompany the peripatetic urbanite from Singapore and Tokyo to Helsinki and Los Angeles. It is increasingly unusual to encounter a person in public who does not pack such devices.

Mark Weiser, longtime Chief Technologist at Xerox PARC who died in 1999, frames this dispersion of information machines as the culmination of the history of computing. He argues that digital computing develops in three stages: an early phase of mainframe machines, a second era of desktop computing, and finally a third stage of ubiquitous computing.²⁵ Weiser regards computers as tools and argues that their best disposition is to become invisible. We need not be confronted by huge mainframes nor have our desks cluttered by monitors, keyboards, and pointing devices. Instead computers, he predicts, will disappear into our notepads, eyeglasses, and clothing. He advocates the complete normalization of computing such that people "cease to be aware of it." Like road signs and billboards, which we read without consciousness of reading, computing should fade into the background of our lives. Weiser's understanding of ubiquitous computing is flawed with the same difficulty as Lefebvre's concept of the everyday: it is thoroughly humanist. Information machines, for Weiser, enhance human activity in the same manner that hammers do.

Weiser's research on new information technologies promotes the disappearance and simultaneously the spread of computing. He developed surfaces, large and small, like notepads and blackboards, which are actually computers. Primitive versions of these devices exist as smart badges, or "tabs," which identify the bearer to doors and buildings, inform others of one's whereabouts, and inform other computers of the identity of the user. Thus doors open automatically, receptionists know the locations of visitors, and "computer terminals retrieve the preferences of whoever is sitting at them."²⁶ The newer devices, "pads" and "boards," would substitute for the conventional desktop. "Scrap computers," as Weiser calls them, would function like Post-It notes or pads of paper, except that as computers they would have all the powers of a

digital machine—memory, storage, communication. Unlike inert pads, these computers could not be lost since they would have the ability to beep their location to their owner. While the “pads” and “boards” are not to my knowledge in use, they certainly would afford conveniences. What Weiser does not acknowledge is the disruption they bring to the familiar picture of everyday life in industrial society. For that reason it behooves us to pause a while before information machines become invisible and reconsider the world where information machines are everywhere.

Ubiquitous computing disturbs the sense of physical location, extending and multiplying the body throughout the globe. Profound risks and possibilities accompany ubiquitous computing. The dangers are already becoming apparent with permanent surveillance as its outcome. Global positioning systems are perhaps convenient for the traveler but information machines, considered in totality, present the possibility that any individual can be located by anyone at any time. In a world where democracy is not at all assured or fully developed, dominant institutions may avail themselves of such surveillance for dubious or malevolent purposes. Reliance on the familiar distinction between the public and the private becomes no longer possible, fundamentally upsetting the markers of freedom in each domain. Information machines fold into prevailing systems of domination, threatening the hard-won liberties of the past few centuries. The nightmares of Gilles Deleuze’s “control society”²⁷ and George Orwell’s *1984* come readily to mind and are even surpassed by futuristic information technologies already extant.

If the risks of everyday life in the brave new world of information technology are extreme, so equally are the possibilities, not simply of conveniences in Weiser’s sense, but of globalizing democracy in a new configuration of humans and machines. As anyone may be located by anyone, so anyone can communicate with anyone else. This novelty makes practical for the first time the term “human.” But it does so, as I have indicated, only through the symbiosis with machines. Humachines are able to connect with others out of mutual interest, no longer limited by the terrible shortcomings of territorial specificity—blood, race, ethnicity, proximity, and scourges of the past millennia some prefer to dignify with the term “community.” Marx’s invocation to the workers of the world to “unite” is now armed with the communications network that makes it possible, albeit by no means guaranteed. If the nation-state and the corporation scurry to bend this network to their brandings with identities (social security numbers, credit card numbers, and so forth), the Internet also resists this distortion by opening new paths of multiple identity, anonymity, temporary identity, fluid identity.

The everyday life emerging in information society is a battleground

over the nature of human identity. If the old order has its way, identities will be stabilized and information machines will become as invisible as they will be ubiquitous. But if alternatives are developed, a global space of cyborgs may emerge whose life task becomes precisely the exploration of identity, the discovery of genders, ethnicities, sexual identities, and personality types that may be enjoyed, experienced, but also transgressed. Henri Lefebvre, with his humanist vision, celebrated a possible everyday of a permanent festival. In a vision of the “city as play” he dreamed of an everyday life that became “a creation of which each citizen and each community would be capable” (*ELM* 13). Paradoxically, only as we leave the human behind, and with it all the detritus of progress so dismaying to Walter’s Benjamin’s angel of history,²⁸ and enter the posthuman epoch, does this vision take on the force of political possibility.

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NOTES

1 For an excellent overview of Lefebvre’s work on the concept of everyday life see Michael Gardiner, *Critiques of Everyday Life* (New York, 2000).

2 One fascinating theory of everyday life in relation to technology is that of Mike Michael, *Reconnecting Culture, Technology and Nature: From Society to Heterogeneity* (New York, 2000). He treats various technologies (walking boots, cars, TV remote controls, dog leashes) in new combinations of machines and human beings, based on theoretical perspectives of Bruno Latour, Donna Haraway, and Michel Serres. He is interested in the mixing of humans and technologies, the formation of new social and cultural subjects. His work is highly recommended but it does not problematize media as such.

3 Henri Lefebvre, *Critique of Everyday Life*, tr. John Moore (London, 1991), p. 94; hereafter cited in text as *C*.

4 Max Weber, *Economy and Society: An Outline of Interpretive Sociology*, vol. 1 (Berkeley, 1978).

5 Henri Lefebvre, “The Everyday and Everydayness,” *Yale French Studies*, 73 (1987), 9; hereafter cited in text as *E*.

6 Kristin Ross in “Streetwise: The French Invention of Everyday Life,” *Parallax*, 2 (1996), 67–75, disagrees with this assessment of Lefebvre’s concept of everyday life. She argues that it is the most coherent of the several French theories of everyday life, including those of Louis Althusser and Michel de Certeau. I am grateful to Ray Guins for pointing me to the special issue of *Parallax* that includes Ross’s essay.

7 Jürgen Habermas, “Modernity, An Incomplete Project,” in *The Anti-Aesthetic: Essays in Postmodern Culture*, ed. Hal Foster (Port Townsend, 1983), pp. 3–15.

8 Norman Angell, *The Great Illusion: A Study of the Relation of Military Power to National Advantage* (Toronto, 1914).

9 Henri Lefebvre, *Everyday Life in the Modern World*, tr. Sacha Rabinovich (New York, 1971), p. 59; hereafter cited in text as *ELM*.

10 Henri Lefebvre, *The Explosion: Marxism and the French Revolution*, tr. Alfred Ehrenfeld (New York, 1969).

- 11 Henri Lefebvre, *Le langage et la société* (Paris, 1966), and Henri Lefebvre, *Au-delà du structuralisme* (Paris, 1971).
- 12 See Fuat Firat and Nikhilesh Dholakia, *Consuming People: From Political Economy to Theaters of Consumption* (New York, 1998).
- 13 One thinks of the work of N. Katherine Hayles, *How We Became Posthuman: Virtual Bodies in Cybernetics, Literature, and Informatics* (Chicago, 1999). See also Sherry Turkle, *Life on the Screen: Identity in the Age of the Internet* (New York, 1995); Allucquere Rosanne Stone, *The War of Desire and Technology at the Close of the Mechanical Age* (Cambridge, Mass., 1995); Jay Bolter and Richard Grusin, "Remediation," *Configurations*, 4 (1996); Lev Manovich, *The Language of New Media* (Cambridge, Mass., 2001). Above all, one must not forget the person who really initiated work on the media, Marshall McLuhan, in *Understanding Media: The Extensions of Man* (New York, 1964).
- 14 For a discussion of the role of the personal case history or anecdote in social and cultural analysis see Mike Michael, *Reconnecting Culture, Technology, and Nature: From Society to Heterogeneity* (New York, 2000), pp. 14–16.
- 15 Dick Hebdige, *Cut 'N' Mix: Culture, Identity, and Caribbean Music* (New York, 1987).
- 16 Lynn Spigel, *Make Room for TV: Television and the Family Ideal in Postwar America* (Chicago, 1992).
- 17 In *Reconnecting Culture, Technology, and Nature: From Society to Heterogeneity*, Mike Michael contrasts television with the Internet and other media regarding the ability of each to promote a common culture. This is increasingly characteristic of television studies; that is, finding an advantage to broadcast systems where the same signal is transmitted to millions of receivers.
- 18 For the change in the public/private relation wrought by television, see Joshua Meyrowitz, *No Sense of Place: The Impact of Electronic Media on Social Behavior* (New York, 1985).
- 19 For an excellent analysis of the impact of television in places outside the home see Anna McCarthy, *Ambient Television: Visual Culture and Public Space* (Durham, 2001).
- 20 See Friedrich A. Kittler, *Discourse Networks 1800/1900*, tr. Michael Metteer (Stanford, 1990), and William Burroughs, *Naked Lunch* (New York, 1959).
- 21 This work is still in the formative stages but there is some progress. See for example Jennifer Kahn, "Let's Make Your Head Interactive," *Wired*, August 2001, 106–15.
- 22 Shoshana Zuboff, *In the Age of the Smart Machine: The Future of Work and Power* (New York, 1988).
- 23 For a subtle investigation of this question see Rayford Guins, "'Now You're Living': The Promise of Home Theater and Deleuze's 'New Freedoms,'" *Television & New Media*, 2 (2001), 351–65.
- 24 Michael Bull, *Sounding out the City: Personal Stereos and the Management of Everyday Life* (New York, 2000); hereafter cited in text as *S*.
- 25 See Mark Weiser, "The Future of Ubiquitous Computing on Campus," *Communications of the ACM*, 41.1 (1998), 41–42, who writes extensively on this subject. See also Mark Weiser, "Less Intrusion Is More Useful," *Computerworld*, 31.7 (1997), 81–82; Mark Weiser, "Some Computer Science Issues in Ubiquitous Computing," *Communications of the ACM*, 36.7 (1993), 74–85; and Mark Weiser, "Ubiquitous Computing," *Computer*, 26.10 (1993), 71–72. I am grateful to Katherine Hayles for informing me about Weiser's work.
- 26 Mark Weiser, "The Computer for the 21st Century," *Scientific American*, September 1991, 94–100.
- 27 Gilles Deleuze, "Postscript on the Societies of Control," *October*, 59 (1992), 3–7.
- 28 Walter Benjamin, "Theses on the Philosophy of History," *Illuminations*, ed. Hannah Arendt (New York, 1969), pp. 257–58.